took his warning as a challenge. I'd already disappointed him in studies. Failure in cricket was not an option.

To be honest, a lot of tribal Pashtuns from the northwest don't give much importance to good education. It's a belief that has held many of us back. But my father was different. He had an immigrant's mind. He aspired for a better life – for himself and his family. After he moved to Karachi, he realized the importance of education from what he saw in the city.

Karachi is sort of the labouring backbone of Pakistan. No other city can match its incredible work ethic. Nobody works harder than Karachiites. Nobody pays more taxes than Karachiites. Nobody has been through more trauma and violence than Karachiites. And yes, nobody hits a better square cut than a Karachiite. More on our special batting ability in a bit.

From U-14, the next stage for me was U-16 cricket and that was a whole different story. I was at Federal Secondary till the fifth grade. By grade six, I couldn't concentrate on studying anymore, even if I wanted to. Frankly, I didn't. Even though it was a pretty good private school, offering O-Levels and a co-education, I still wasn't interested in studies. I was quite sure that school – be it private or public – was never my thing. Learning in a static environment was quite disabling. I felt claustrophobic in a classroom; even today I cramp uncomfortably during sit-down instruction lessons with coaches. I don't like tables and chairs and blackboards. Yuck.

So, one day, I decided I'd go to my father and give him an honest deal: pull me out of Federal Secondary and put me in a cheaper, government-run school, where one didn't have to do much, sometimes not even turn up, but where at least the cricket teams were better. I thought I was being honest with him, being open and austere about the choices I wanted to make. I wanted to work on my cricket and not be held back by the high demands and costs of private school, and I didn't want him to spend more than he could afford on my education. I thought that by reasoning with him I would get some appreciation.

Instead, all I got was another beating – a particularly harsh one. My father was angry that I had had the courage to say what I had said to his face. Confronting your elders isn't the Pashtun way, nor is defying their orders. But I meant it all in good faith, and I know that eventually, years later, he realized it.

Life went on. As the war in Afghanistan and the tribal areas came to Karachi and the city grew more violent, it led to what began to be known as Karachi's 'Kalashnikov Culture', inspired by the heavy influx of weapons and narcotics into mainland Pakistan. I remained focused on my game. I took my father's disapproval and his beatings but managed to get into a government school. I didn't have much except my perseverance. Some call it stubbornness. It's still my greatest weapon, I think.

The government-run school had a fantastic cricket team, physically very demanding, and it didn't take me long to join it. I remember it comprised primarily of boys from the ninth and tenth grades. I was the youngest one – a sixth grader – in the team and played inter-school and district-level cricket with the big boys. It was a great honour, my first formal team experience and, like today, I stood out then as well. I was a young kid with a big body. Things worked out.

On the field, I always had a physical advantage. I think it's because of my genes. Pashtuns are built strong and tough. It's the way we are. It's the way many mountain people are. Though not very well schooled like other cricketing greats of Pakistan, my mental strength came from my love for the game – a blinding, unflinching, mad, absolutely crazy love for the game. Day or